

content that has no structure (e.g. MIT OpenCourseWare), but they're important in the context of an online course. A MOOC might have a feedback system in place but it's usually generic in nature and is unable to recognise individual peaks and faults. The scale of an online course usually makes in-depth feedback impossible. A human instructor is simply incapable of correcting a thousand papers and offer detailed feedback. Without a strong feedback system, a student may end up committing mistakes of the same type repeatedly, which is quite destructive to the whole learning process.

Low retention and completion rate

While online education courses boast of a high number of registrations, very few students actually complete these courses and a majority of them give up halfway. A considerable percentage of students drop out even before the course gets underway. A statistical analysis conducted in March 2014 of edX's popular Circuits and Electronics course suggests that only about 6% of the 2.5 lakh odd registered students actually completed the course. A staggering 55% dropped out before the course even began. These are stats you can't argue with and have been affecting the success of online education severely. Sebastian Thurn, the founder of Udacity, shocked by the discouraging statistics of measly completion rates tried introducing remedial measures such as mentorship, gamification of courses and higher levels of interaction in Udacity's Statistics 101 course; however the dropout rate failed to improve.

Even more discouraging is the fact that even among the students who do complete a course, the pass percentage is hardly impressive. This clearly suggests that the online education revolution is highly uneven and hailing it as a paradigm shift in learning and education could be premature.

Too structured

A holistic learning environment can only be created if the student is given creative freedom. Students who thrive on an open and free environment will find rigid coursework limiting. Online courses have a preset pattern and follow a framework consisting of timely quizzes, assignments and lectures. While this may not be a bad thing overall, it may not appeal to a student who prefers to follow her own pace of studying.

Further, students undertaking massive open online courses (MOOCs) that follow a similar rigid structure are inadvertently being trained to think in the same structured way, and this might limit diversity and originality